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I took away from this championship was the **conviction** that I could take on any boxer.

In the course of my career, I have become used to travel and to the different ways that things work in other countries. One time, in China, we were given chopsticks to eat our meals with. Just when I had painfully begun to master the art of using a knife and fork, I had to use two sticks to fill my stomach. I ended up using both my hands to hold the chopstick to pick up the food and push it into my mouth. My teammates asked for spoons but I tried to manage with the sticks. It helped that I really enjoy Chinese food. I was hungry enough that I managed the complex work required – I ate enough to **sate** my appetite and my **palate**. After five years of travelling, I started taking along some packed food from home.

On my return, Delhi gave me a warm welcome at the airport. Back in Imphal, I was greeted with garlands and drumbeats and dancing. There was a victory ride across town, a **felicitation** programme was held in Langol, an area that houses the government quarters. Thanksgiving prayers were said and words of praise and **adulation** were showered on me. I was presented with a traditional shawl. Oja Ibomcha was also present and was duly felicitated. When I spoke to the people in Langol that day, I spoke of my hope that I would win gold in future tournaments.

That first international medal, a silver, will always mean a lot to me. The fight and all that followed are clearly **etched** in my memory. But deep inside, I was not happy with a silver. As I touched down in India, I vowed that the next time I would bring back a gold. I knew I was good enough.

The silver in Pennsylvania and the prize money from the government had put an end to my immediate financial worries. But I wanted a job too, for that alone can bring long-term security and a steady income. Also, around the time that I was getting married, I had no savings except a couple of life insurance policies. After my second World Championship gold, the Manipur government offered me the post of Sub-Inspector, which I accepted in 2005. I had long dreamt of getting a government job through the sports quota, and it was finally fulfilled. I earned a salary of Rs. 15,000 in that first job. The thing about jobs that are obtained through the sports quota is that we are not required to go in to work as regularly as our colleagues because we tend to be away at camps and tournaments through much of the year. I go to office when necessary. And every time I need to go out of station, I am required to take leave and inform the department.

My medal **haul** continued after my marriage, putting an end to **speculation** among my family and friends around that particular topic. I retained the world